

## Two Surveys from 1987

### Shere Hite Survey

In 1987, researcher [Shere Hite](#) published *Women and Love*, a study about American women and their relationships with men. Hite distributed approximately **100,000 questionnaires** and received about **4,500 completed questionnaires**.

The women who responded reported very high levels of dissatisfaction with their relationships. Among Hite's findings:

- **84%** said they were emotionally dissatisfied with their relationships.
- **95%** reported experiencing some form of emotional or psychological harassment from the men in their relationships.
- **70%** of women who had been married for five years or more reported having sex outside their marriages.
- Only **16%** said that arguments helped clear the air and led to better understanding.

Hite used these results to argue that dissatisfaction among American women in relationships was widespread.

#### Questions

- Identify the population Hite was attempting to study.
  - Identify the sample and give the sample size.
  - Do you think the women who responded were representative of all American women?
  - What percentage of the women who were sent questionnaires actually responded?
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### Washington Post–ABC News Poll

After Hite's findings received widespread attention, the **Washington Post and ABC News** conducted a national public-opinion poll examining similar issues. They interviewed **1,505 adults nationwide by telephone**.

Their results painted a very different picture of American relationships:

- **97%** of respondents rated their romantic relationships as either **good or excellent**.
- About **two-thirds** of married people said their partners talked about their thoughts and feelings often enough to satisfy them.
- About **86%** of married respondents said that arguments tended to clear the air.
- More than **80%** of respondents said they felt they were equal partners in their relationships.
- About **75%** of respondents thought Hite's estimate that 70% of women married five years or more were having affairs was too high.

The Washington Post–ABC News poll had a reported margin of sampling error of approximately **±3 percentage points**.

#### Questions

- Identify the population the Washington Post–ABC News poll was attempting to study.
- Identify the sample and give the sample size.
- Compare the results of the two surveys. For example, Hite reported that **84% of women were dissatisfied**, while the Washington Post–ABC News poll found that **97% of respondents rated their relationships as good or excellent**. Why might these surveys have produced such different results?